

## The rights of women



The democracies that followed the revolutions in France and America were established on principles of liberty and equality. There was frequent reference to 'natural rights', especially in the French *Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen* of 1789. However, the playwright Olympe de Gouges pointed out a glaring omission with her response, the *Declaration of the Rights of Woman and the Female Citizen*. In Britain, Mary Wollstonecraft similarly replied to Thomas Paine's *Rights of Man* with *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman*. A major step towards equal rights for women came with philosopher Harriet Taylor's friendship with

and later marriage to John Stuart Mill. He saw her as an intellectual equal, and as a respected philosopher and Member of Parliament, was better able to promote her cause, writing *The Subjection of Women* based on her ideas. The first male philosopher since Plato and Epicurus to advocate sexual equality, he campaigned for women's rights, and in 1866 became the first MP to propose votes for women.